

New Zealand: South Island Passes & Golf

Ten days from Christchurch: Arthur's Pass to the wild West Coast, the glaciers, Haast Pass, the Crown Range to Queenstown, the road to Milford Sound, and Lindis Pass past Aoraki / Mount Cook, with golf at Millbrook and Jack's Point.

10 days: 9 riding, 2 golf rounds · **Riding:** about 1,800 km (1,120 mi) · **Start and finish:** Christchurch · **Best:** February to March · **Drive on the left**

Arrive Christchurch

Fly into Christchurch (via Auckland or Sydney) and collect the bikes.

Overnight: Christchurch

Day 1 Christchurch to Hokitika

About 250 km (155 mi)

West across the Canterbury Plains and up into the Southern Alps over Arthur's Pass, past Castle Hill's limestone boulders, then down the Otira Viaduct to the West Coast at Greymouth and south to Hokitika.

By way of: Springfield · Castle Hill · Arthur's Pass · Otira Viaduct · Kumara

Overnight: Hokitika

Day 2 Hokitika to Haast

About 280 km (175 mi)

South through rainforest to the Franz Josef and Fox glaciers, with a stop at Lake Matheson for the mirror view of Aoraki / Mount Cook, then the empty coast road to Haast.

By way of: Ross · Lake Ianthe · Franz Josef · Fox Glacier · Lake Matheson · Knights Point

Overnight: Haast

Day 3 Haast to Wanaka

About 140 km (85 mi)

Up the Haast River and over Haast Pass past the Blue Pools and Thunder Creek Falls, then along Lakes Wanaka and Hawea, one of the great lakeside rides in the country.

By way of: Haast Pass · Blue Pools · Thunder Creek Falls · Lake Wanaka · The Neck · Lake Hawea

Overnight: Wanaka

Day 4 Wanaka to Queenstown, golf

About 70 km (45 mi)

Over the Crown Range Road, the highest main road in New Zealand, and down the switchbacks to Arrowtown, then an afternoon round at Millbrook Resort before the short run into Queenstown.

By way of: Cardrona · Crown Range Road · Arrowtown

Overnight: Queenstown

Day 5 Queenstown to Te Anau

About 170 km (105 mi)

Along Lake Wakatipu on the Devil's Staircase road to Kingston, then across the farmland of northern Southland to Te Anau on the edge of Fiordland.

By way of: Devil's Staircase · Kingston · Garston · Mossburn

Overnight: Te Anau

Day 6 Milford Sound and back

About 240 km (150 mi)

The Milford Road through the Eglinton Valley and Mirror Lakes, through the Homer Tunnel, and down to Milford Sound for a cruise to the Tasman Sea, then back to Te Anau. Leave early to beat the tour buses.

By way of: Eglinton Valley · Mirror Lakes · Homer Tunnel · Milford Sound

Overnight: Te Anau

Day 7 Te Anau to Queenstown

About 170 km (105 mi)

Back to Queenstown, with time for the Glenorchy road along the head of Lake Wakatipu in the afternoon.

By way of: Mossburn · Kingston · Glenorchy road (optional)

Overnight: Queenstown

Day 8 Golf at Jack's Point

A round at Jack's Point, between Lake Wakatipu and the Remarkables, one of the most scenic courses in the world.

Overnight: Queenstown

Day 9 Queenstown to Lake Tekapo

About 260 km (160 mi)

Through the Kawarau Gorge and Central Otago's Pinot Noir country at Cromwell, over Lindis Pass, then past Lake Pukaki with Aoraki / Mount Cook at the end of the lake, to Lake Tekapo and the Church of the Good Shepherd.

By way of: Kawarau Gorge · Cromwell · Lindis Pass · Omarama · Twizel · Lake Pukaki

Overnight: Lake Tekapo

Day 10 Lake Tekapo to Christchurch

About 230 km (145 mi)

Over Burkes Pass and through Fairlie and Geraldine, then across the Canterbury Plains back to Christchurch.

By way of: Burkes Pass · Fairlie · Geraldine · Rakaia

Overnight: Christchurch

Depart Fly home from Christchurch

Return the bikes and fly home.

Best time to go

- Best: February to March, late summer. Settled weather, long days and quieter roads once the school holidays end in early February.
- Good: November and April. Fewer people and spring or autumn colour, with cooler mornings and a chance of snow on the high passes.
- Busiest: mid-December to January, the New Zealand summer holidays, with heavy camper-van traffic.
- Avoid: June to August. Snow and ice on the passes and the Milford Road.

BMW rental near Christchurch

- CircleNZ: BMW F 900 GS, F 850 GS Adventure, F 800 GS and F 750 GS, 20 minutes from the airport, with several drop-off points (circlenz.co.nz)
- South Pacific Motorcycle Tours, North Canterbury: BMW R 1250 GS and R 1250 RT, plus Harley-Davidson and Triumph; airport pickup (motorbiketours.co.nz)
- Riderly lists other private and dealer rentals around Christchurch (riderly.com)

Golf

- Millbrook Resort, Arrowtown
- Jack's Point, Queenstown

Riding notes

- The West Coast gets heavy rain in any season; pack proper rain gear.
- Fuel is sparse between Fox Glacier and Wanaka and on the Milford Road. Fill up in Haast and Te Anau.
- Sandflies are fierce on the West Coast and in Fiordland; bring repellent.

Draft route. Distances and times are approximate; check road, pass and ferry conditions before each day.